

Interrogating the Politics of Folk Gender, Space and Identity in Goalpariya Folk Music of Assam

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The analysis of *Goalpariya* folk music of Assam and its various facets helps deconstruct the conventional notion of “folk” as a neutral, static, historically continuous, and an unproblematic concept. The interconnections and linkages of folk music with the themes of identity assertion, tradition, authenticity, contexts of appropriation, and overall dynamism inherent within the concept of folk are also explored.

Given that there are different forms of identity (be it social, cultural, economic, political, regional, etc),¹ my focus is solely on identities constituted in and through folk music. Such constructions, however, often lead to the constitution of an “inauthentic other” (labelling as inauthentic folk artists). By looking at the construction and assertion of identities through *Goalpariya* folk music and its changing nature (rather than its presumed stability), along with the function of folk music in creating dissent, I hope to engage in critically looking at the “politics of folk,” so that the concept of “folk”² can be problematised.

In this article, I will first be looking at the connection between folk and identity politics and how this connection is further getting strengthened due to the current complexities of “new media.” Then, I will be primarily focusing on the songs to derive the subversive potential that may be inherent within this folk. Understanding this paradox of folk will assist us to foreground “folk” as not-so-much an “innocent” category, but a dynamic category of analysis in itself.

Methodology

Since I am interested in analysing folk songs and its connection to gendered and political intricacies, I have used ethnomusicology as the broad methodological framework to locate my research. Ethnomusicology is a tradition of scholarship concerned with the social and cultural study of music and is rooted in ethnography, which is to say the study of musical practice in cultural context. Through the lens of ethnomusicology, I have been able to study *Goalpariya Lokageet* (folk song) in its cultural context, such that the ideology and politics surrounding it,

the relationships between music, space, and identity, the ways in which language functions, the relation of music with gender and sexuality, and the construction of identities ranging from the smallest group to the most powerful nation in and through folk music, have become clear.

The tools/methods that I have used as part of this methodology are textual analysis of songs and in-depth interviews with diverse stakeholders associated with the folk form like singers, musicians, people generally involved with the folk, etc. The use of both text-based as well as empirical research methods has helped me understand the textuality as well as the contextuality in the politics of folk music.

The study area for this research broadly consisted of two districts of Assam, that is, Kamrup and Dhubri. Within Kamrup, the majority of the interviews were conducted in the city of Guwahati, as most of the respondents now reside in Guwahati city. On the other hand, some of the interviews were conducted in Gauripur, a city in Dhubri district (earlier part of Goalpara district), the primary area where this folk tradition originated.

Whose ‘Folk’ Is It?

It is important to clarify at the outset that Goalpara, as it is known today, is an administrative district that has been carved out of the undivided Goalpara district of colonial Assam. It is this larger erstwhile Goalpara district, the westernmost district in Assam, from which the name *Goalpariya Lokageet* had emerged. Being the westernmost district, it was uniquely located on the border, bounded by the districts of Jalpaiguri and Cooch Behar in West Bengal and Rangpur in Bangladesh, to its west. Therefore, Goalpara was seen as a historically transitional area between proto-“Assam” and proto-“Bengal.” This liminal position led to the people there being dubbed as “Prantobashi” or the “inhabitants of the Pranto, that is, frontier” (Misra 2006: 200). Politically as well, Goalpara has never been an independent political

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entity. Hence, its history can be understood only in connection to the different dynasties that ruled it from time to time. Due to this unique form of political and spatial ambiguity, Goalpariya lokageet has a distinctive set of controversies associated with it. It, therefore, becomes an interesting genre to locate identity politics that may be enacted through the medium of folk traditions.

Goalpariya lokageet (presumably sung in the Rajbanshi language)³ is mostly associated with the Koch Rajbanshi community who formed a major part of the total population of Goalpara. However, the diverse and contrasting narratives that were coming through my interviews problematise the straightforward link between the folk and the community. Because of the emergence of these songs from a space of liminality,⁴ there are a lot of contentions over whose songs they are. There were some interviewees who made a conscious attempt to establish the Koch Rajbanshi community as the “folklore community,” a term used by Joyce Flueckiger. “Folklore community” is one that “shares both the knowledge of a particular folklore repertoire and the rules by which its members communicate through those genres. Members of a folklore community know and agree upon who is traditionally permitted to perform particular genres and under what circumstances” (Flueckiger 1996: 178). She has argued that the “claiming” of the different folk forms itself shows an identification of a self-perceived regional identity (Appadurai et al 1991: 12–13). On the contrary, the disputes regarding the link between Koch Rajbanshis and Goalpariya lokageet, problematise the very idea of folklore community. Such contestations over the authentic folklore community bring out the way people try to ascertain their identity in and through a folk form. Interestingly, the anonymity of folk songs was also often utilised by many to opine about the uncertainty of its origin. The politics of authenticity, therefore, establishes the past connected to this folk music to be polyphonic and contested.

Similar “politics of pastness” also occurs in relation to the place/space. In the case of Goalpariya folk music, the story of the past is told from a particular

geopolitical space further exhibiting the regional politics of the folk form. Given Goalpara’s unique position in the geopolitical scenario, I could visibly gauge at the ways people were trying to construct and reassert it as the “folklore region” for Goalpariya lokageet through various practices like nomenclature, call for “correct” pronunciation (given the similarity of Goalpariya dialect with both Assamese and Bengali), creating exclusive boundary as to who can perform or practise the folk “authentically,” etc. This brings forth the aspect of how folk can often be utilised to develop a strong sense of identification with the space/place of its origin. In other words, folk music can therefore be employed to accentuate the spatial identity. This feeds into the larger theory of how certain musical practices tend to anchor identities (both personal and collective) into specific places, towns and territories. Biddle and Knights (2007: 2) have called this an idealisation of place, especially in the context of different music(s) moving away from their spaces of production or creation.

Reconstructing the ‘Authentic’

With the impending changes in global cultural economy and incursions of newer forms of media, Goalpariya folk form has changed a lot. With these changes, the attempt to establish and preserve the folk in its “pure form” has become even stronger. Therefore, I would like to trace the changes in a way which brings forth how folk music too gets embroiled within the discourse of change, and how this results in efforts to retain the “original” folk in myriad ways.

Presentation to representation: When the folk form got transferred from the “natural setting” to the stage, changes started to take place, in terms of performance, lyrics, the manner of singing, instruments used, etc. Along with transformations in the norms of performativity, the stage brings in new stakeholders into the domain of folk, like organisers (who organise the various functions and *melas* where the folk is showcased) who are largely involved in the control of stage performances. These organisers

usually play a very powerful role in the representation of the folk form. They especially control the stage performances by deciding who can sing what, how to dress up, how one should appear while performing folk on the stage, etc. Such controlling also suggests the ways folk can transform from being quotidian to being utilised as a cultural exhibit. My interviews with different members involved with the folk, revealed how certain changes are brought in to showcase the folk in a sanitised form. For instance, *Hudum* songs⁵ that form an integral part of Goalpariya folk music have now been recontextualised because of the explicit sexual connotations in the songs.

Apart from these limitations, one of the crucial positive changes has been the way several of the women singers have now taken up the playing of instruments. During my interview, one of the research participants, Purbi Baruah, sang to me while at the same time played the *ditora*. Also, for many of the female folk artists, performances on stage have proved to be revolutionary, as it has given them the opportunity to come out and be who they are. In other words, some have taken this chance to showcase their embodied selves.

Fusion or confusion: In contemporary times, apart from public stages, Goalpariya folk music has long entered the medium of radio, cassettes, internet, etc, especially with the rise of mass media and information technologies. There has been a literal shift of the folk from the space of the villages to that of towns. One can notice that most of the cassettes and songs that have become popular through recordings have some amount of innovations in them. It is usually the music industry (which now includes the entire gamut of musicians, audiences, sound engineers, festival promoters, etc) that stimulates such stylistic variations. The change in audience aesthetics also pushes the performers to meet new demands. Peter Kvetko (2004) has talked about how with increasing levels of globalisation, there has been an eventual increase in Indi-pop, especially due to economic liberalisation which was mostly promoted by multinational labels like

Sony, BMG, etc. These changes and effects have led to the constitution of a new kind of music that often utilises folk music along with several other musical genres. This I prefer to call the fusion form of the folk.

Nevertheless, there are several layers of complexities that are knitted into the word fusion. My field interviews with some singers, who are into fusion music, highlighted how singers create an unambiguous categorisation in terms of deciding what elements of the folk can/should change with the influx of technology. Folk music, in this sense, appears to have different elements, where changes in some elements are considered okay as compared to some other elements. For instance, Kalpana Patowary, a celebrated folk singer of Assam, considered the change in rhythm acceptable in contrast to the change in the *gayaki/dhek* (the projection of voice or the style of singing). Through her constant elaborations of how not to sing, it was obvious how one tries to justify the use of fusion in very many ways. Her re-emphasising of the importance of keeping folk sentiment alive, speaks a lot of the fusion dynamics. Creating fusion music, therefore, did not take away the questions of authenticity from the larger discourse of folk politics.

Many also felt a need for the folk to change to take it on to the national level, so that everyone knows and gets the inspiration to take up the songs. So, unlike the often used term of appropriation to refer to new performance contexts and performers, it is crucial to recognise that in some of the cases, the “tradition” is self-consciously packaged for both Indian and international audiences to represent the region, which need not necessarily be called appropriation (Flueckiger 1996: 151). The availability of mass-media technologies like radio, television and the internet has now made such self-conscious endeavours possible and convenient.

Goalpariya lokageet is now performed and sung by different actors and is transmitted through media like YouTube and Facebook. Goalpariya folk has also entered the realm of Coke Studio,⁶ which is a music television series featuring performances of various musicians ranging

from folk, classical, jazz, pop, etc. This could, however, be seen as a strategy for preserving or “producing locality” (Appadurai 1996: 178). The singers, however, often make adjustments to uphold the folk and, at the same time, manoeuvre their lives with it. This was an important contradiction in terms of how in spite of engaging themselves with fusion music, they always valorise the folk part of the hybrid culture and strategically deal with criticisms of being “inauthentic.”

Who can take the stage? However, the emergence of these new forms of music brings us to some critical questions like who has visibility vis-à-vis those who are losing livelihoods. Also, who can even afford to switch livelihoods? In this light, one can understand the figure of Pratima Baruah Pandey from a very different vantage point. Pratima Pandey, one of the quintessential Goalpariya folk singers, who brought out the folk into the performative location, has several credits to her name. She was, undoubtedly, the flag-bearer of Goalpariya lokageet. However, it is important to critically look at her caste/class privileges (being an upper-class royal family girl), which enabled her to acquire the symbolic capital as the most “authentic” Goalpariya folk artist. Thus, one must be aware of the power differentials associated with becoming the “artist” she had become. Thus, it is important to recognise how caste, class, ethnicity, and other forms of social identity delimit the category of “folk artist.”

It has been seen that for many of the folk performers, who have mostly stuck with the “original” folk form with the hope of “preserving” the culture, the profession is dwindling. Despite such tough living conditions, they want to stick to their profession, as, in their words, “they are in love” with what they are doing. However, after a point they also contradict themselves saying that it is not a good enough income generator. Now especially with the changes in audience perceptions and needs, their art has become even more difficult to “sell.” So, within these changing circumstances, it becomes extremely necessary to locate

their desire for “performance” within the larger discourse of “power representation.” Therefore, the changing trends of music-making have introduced a new form of dialectics in the life of some performers.

How to sing? Throughout all my interviews, the question posed about the changes/transformations of the folk unanimously brought out issues of “authenticity” and validity. Many of my interviewees often tend to construe and imagine a “correct” form of the folk. Such notions of the correct form inevitably leads to the politics of authenticity. Thus, such claims of authenticity frequently lead to the constitution of an “authentic artist.” The “authentic artists” then try to justify their authenticity by pointing out the ways they are striving to keep the “folk feeling” alive. Notions of “folk distortion” also repeatedly brought up the importance of “preserving” the folk in its original form. Such notions of safekeeping are often connected to the act of self-identification, such that folk validity is seen as getting undermined by “objectification and potential de-contextualisation” (Friedman 1994: 104).

By connecting the folk to one’s original identity, the act of preservation stands to become a political act. Interestingly, workshops and competitions have become an important medium of keeping up the preservation project. Such steps towards preservation bring forth the nostalgia for “cultural purity” that often exists among the people. One can also gather how the transition from “folk” to “modern” is therefore, time and again, seen as wrong or immoral. In discussing questions of authenticity, I could also notice a reiteration from most of the folk singers who then try to equate folk with tradition.

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However, it is important to examine the fact that some of the traditions they have referred to, have only become traditions in a way that they have been constructed and constituted through several practices (like styles of singing, kinds of voices used, ways of performances, etc). This politics of authenticity can therefore be closely interlinked with Hobsbawm's theory of "invention of tradition," according to which tradition is a practice of formalisation and ritualisation, often referenced with respect to the "past" (Hobsbawm 1983). It then becomes extremely important to explore how the memory of pastness is used to bring about the validity of the folk. However, to quote from Appadurai et al (1991: 22–23)

the problem of pastness itself changes as the modes of cultural reproduction change. As traditions become mass-produced, as cultural artefacts become commodified, as intimate performances become available to large audiences, the pastness of the present becomes itself a plastic relationship.

Thus, one needs to recognise the "politics of pastness," that is, the fact that "the past is a social construction mainly, if not wholly, shaped by the concerns of the present" (Coser 1992: 25), and that it is "collective memory" that strives to keep the cultural continuity intact (Coser 1992: 30). It is important to realise that in a postcolonial world it is almost impossible to think of an autonomous or an internally coherent "authentic culture," as all of us now live in a world marked by "porous cultural boundaries" (Rosaldo 1988: 87).

However, by critiquing such claims to authenticity, I do not mean to take the position of cultural relativism either, as I do understand the importance of their struggle for assertion, through which they could engage in constituting a sense of shared public. Instead, by bringing notice to their call for authenticity, I want to bring out the complex dynamics that surround the concept of folk. Goalpariya folk music here has become the object of several contestations and struggles. In the process, the voices of those who originally engaged with the folk have been silenced. Such silencing indicates the politics behind the contentions, which further blocks us

from drawing a linear relation between folk and identity.

Moving from the politics of identity assertion, the next section will delve into the songs in themselves and the dissenting aspect that can be attached to Goalpariya folk genre. Understanding both the aspects of folk will help to locate the paradox within which folk music may function.

Subversive Potential

Apart from being a political tool, folk songs can also become a tool of resistance for the marginalised sections of the society. From a feminist perspective, I have tried to look at these songs as resources that give us cues as to how individuals (here women, as I am specifically looking at the songs mostly sung by women) often resist and question the dominant power structures within which they are embedded. Such an understanding helps us look at feminist politics in a much broader way.

Goalpariya lokageet has within it several diverse varieties and themes. Major themes emerging from the songs are those of spirituality/longing/desire/separation, etc. Based on these several themes, they are categorised into different genres. Two major categories of Goalpariya lokageet are called *Bhawaiya* and *Chatka*. *Bhawaiya* is a class of love songs whose lyrical compositions often express suppressed passion. The *Chatka*, on the other hand, is short and crisp (Dutta 2009). They are usually sarcastic and speedy and are similar to parody. Some of the basic instruments that are seen as essential for the performance of the folk are *ditora*, *sarinda*, *dhak/dhol*, and flute.

Expressing the unexpressed: Most of the *Bhawaiya* (slow-paced) songs are tied to the theme of migration. They are solo songs portraying the love, pain and pleasure, union and separation of the men and women of the region. This theme of migration can be tied to the historical context within which Goalpara was positioned. Since erstwhile Goalpara was a feudal society, the socio-economic scenario of the region was characterised by the dominance of the land owning

classes like the *jamindars*. Working for these feudal lords, the peasants/serfs would migrate to different places for various kinds of work. It is then that the wives used to sing the *Bhawaiya* songs for their absentee husbands. An important figure that recurs in Goalpariya lokageet is that of the *mahout* (people involved in domesticating wild elephants). The fact that migration was a predominantly male affair, also comes forth through these folksongs because the songs are mainly in women's voice where they are expressing their melancholy as a result of their separation. Through their lamentation, they explicitly talk about how they had to leave their natal home and family and then find husbands who leave for work. A section of one such song is as follows:

*Are Gouripuriya mahout kande o, Sokhi ghor bari chhariya sokhi o,
O mur sarin hatir mahout re jidin mahout Bhutan jai,
Narir mon mor juria rohoi re!
Akashe te nai re chondro, Tara kemon jole ...
Je Narir Purush Nai O, O Tar Rupe Ki Kaam Kore Sokhi O,
O mur Makhna Hatir Mahout Re, Ji Din Mahout Shikar Jai
Narir Mon Mor kandia Rohoi Re
Ai charilong bhai charilong, charilong sonar puri
Biao kareya chariya asilong o, sakhi alpa bayaser nari sakhi o,
O more haay hastir kainya re, khaneko daya nai tor mahut okla giya re.⁷*

(The Mahout from Gauripur cries, for he has left his home, O my friend, My elephant girl, the day Mahout goes to Bhutan, My mind as a woman becomes distressed! Now that there is no moon in the sky, how will the stars glow? The women whose husband is not nearby, oh! How will her beauty work? O my friend, the day Mahout goes for hunting, My heart cries! I left my mother, I left my brother, I left my golden house to marry you, O Mahout, please have some pity for your young wife, Whom you have left and gone to work).⁸

In the above passage, one can see the woman expressing her desires and longings for her love. But, at the same time, she is also showing sympathy for her lover and trying to express his feelings through her words. One can also notice the explicit symbolism that is prevalent in this section, where the

moon (a unitary element) represents the man, while the stars (signifying multiplicity) stand for woman. Such an analogy gives us an idea of the kind of power relationships that were inherent in the society.

The element of *biraha* or deep emotion comes out very strongly through such songs. It can be especially culled out from the elongated tones that the singers sing with, in a way that the last word of every line is lengthened with touching resonances. One can almost feel the throes of desperate passion throbbing with pain. As Margaret Trawick (1991) in her analysis of a song by an untouchable Tamil woman has also written that such songs, in a sense, elucidate and strengthen certain life events, like separation and suffering in human relationships. Such autobiographical narratives that distinctly elaborate the pain/passion can be seen as leading to a construction of the “experiential self” (Appadurai et al 1991: 10). In other words, as soon as it is sung through a song, the expression and tonality bring life into it and almost invisibilises the thin line between expressive genres and the real. Therefore, one can glimpse into the numerous struggles of the “lived body” through these songs. Such songs also take us back to Ramanujan’s (1991) idea, where he argued that the very idea of a woman speaking through texts expresses or results in the construction of her self. An otherwise silent woman may therefore become a speaking woman (Appadurai et al 1991: 9).

As Kirin Narayan (1986) has written, “songs provide a medium for expressing emotions that are taboo topics in everyday conversations” (as cited in Jassal 2012: 2). It, hence, becomes extremely crucial to read those emotions within the songs. Since singing can play a critical role in venting emotions (Jassal 2012: 153), I have tried to capture the songs as discourses of emotions that allow for the free expression of one’s feelings in socially acceptable ways. Such emotional discourses, however, are often shaped by the political economy of which they are a part. Such an exploration allows us to recognise expression of powerful emotions, particularly by those who are

lower in power hierarchies, as an act of resistance, a rupture of the normalisation of everyday power relations and hence as an inherently political act. We, as feminist researchers, often talk about bringing out the voices of the marginalised. Here, the songs in a very literal sense allow me to tap into those voices which remain critically unheard, in a sense that although almost everyone has listened to these songs in Assam, they do not generally consider them as epistemic resources that reflect women’s “subaltern consciousness” (Jassal 2012: 4).

Gendered spaces of performance: Apart from Bhawaiya, I would like to elaborate on two other genres within this folk, which were of particular interest for this research. They are *Kati Puja* and *Hudum Puja* songs. These songs were especially interesting because, first, the women folk exclusively sing them and men are almost forbidden from entering. Thus, the relation between women and rituals is accentuated through such gendered performances. Second, although the songs are ritualistic or devotional in character, they along with their performances are filled with sexual/erotic imagery. I could not be a part of any such performance as the people today claim to have stopped its practice altogether. So, the interviews were my only source to understand what happened during such performances and the kind of songs sung during that time. An example of a *Hudum geet*:

*Hilhilyache kamorta mor sirsiryache gao
Konte kona geile aela mui hudumar nagal paon.
Patani khan pareche khasia aisek re huduma
dyaoa.
Tur bade mui achong basiya.*

(My waist is eager to be clasped in your arms,
My body is love sick to meet Hudum.
My dress is dishevelled.
O Hudum, I am waiting for you.
Do come and embrace me).⁹

As already mentioned in the previous sections, these performances were a means to please the Hudum deity or the god of rain. When I interviewed the singers, they often tied their nakedness in performance to a kind of sacrifice they used to do for the betterment of the nature. However, I see them as more than just acts of sacrifice, and rather it

points out how such rituals may provide a space for women to blur the boundaries between the “normal” and the “abnormal.” To cite from Narayan, “this emphasis on songs being sung from duty and from happiness (in this case from sacrifice) could be a form of ‘feminist coding’ (Radner and Lanser 1987), making for a ‘hidden transcript’ (Scott 1991) or ‘veiled sentiments’ (Abu-Lughod 1986) whereby women could exchange subversive messages” (Narayan 1997: 42). Now, on the other hand, most women are not allowed to indulge in such performances by their male companions. Henceforth, with the onset of modernity, it has become difficult for women to keep up with these traditional performances. This clearly resonates with Sumanta Banerjee’s article on 19th-century Bengal where he discussed how the folk forms that speak explicitly of women’s desires (which usually tend to originate from the lower class/caste groups due to the “moral ethics” burdened upon the upper-caste/class women) tend to be marginalised with respect to other genres as part of the sanitisation process. She talks about how this marginalisation continued due to the conceited and persistent ideological campaigns of the *bhadralok*¹⁰ against these cultural forms along with several socio-economic changes like the diminishing number of old patrons, rise of the book culture, etc (Banerjee 1990). Thus, the changes in the folk form often attempt to fit the desires of the upper- and middle-class elite’s ideas of Victorian morality. Thus, it becomes extremely important to engage in what I call song conversations, which allow us to delve into the implicit sexual politics at work.

Such rituals and practices where women are separate from men and rituals and practices which exclude men, serve in themselves as a “means of resisting and setting limits to domination” (Jassal 2012: 14). In such a case, as Jassal has rightly mentioned, one must see agency as “capacity for action” created and enabled by specific relations of power, rather than narrowly seeing it as resistance to relations of domination.

Therefore, as long as we consider the context as equally enlightening as the text, it is extremely important to

analyse the songs in terms of not just who is singing what, but also who can be present during different performances. Such gendering of the spaces in which singing can happen becomes essentially crucial to the cause of my research. Such splitting majorly has to do with the kinds of songs sung and lyrics within them. The musical world is therefore gendered in terms of both genres of songs and also the spaces of their performances.

Thus, songs in itself provide us with an understanding of how women may operate their agency through diverse mediums, one being songs.

Conclusions

By looking at Goalpariya folk music and its various facets, I have tried to deconstruct the conventional notion of folk as a neutral, static, historically continuous, and an unproblematic concept. As detailed out in the previous sections, folk music can be and is often used to establish and assert identities of various kinds, such that they inherently become invested with identity politics. However, apart from the politics associated with the concept of folk, talking about Goalpariya folk music has also given me an opportunity to begin conversations about the traditions of a culture that has been almost marginalised in relation to other folk cultures of Assam. By bringing into light the explicit mentions of women's desires, sexuality, needs, etc, within the corpus of Goalpariya folk songs, I have also recognised the subversive potential inherent within these songs. This paradox of folk becoming both a tool for liberation as well as a political tool is something I have tried to capture through the research.

Hence, it is important to see how folk music is often used to assert identities based on community, space, or gender. This assertion often becomes problematic as it is fraught with the question of who does the folk belong to? At the same time, the emergence of new contexts has further reinforced this identity assertion, as people are now working more to preserve the folk in its "original" fashion. Such reinforcement has raised the question: "How should the

folk be?" However, this movement of Goalpariya folk from one space to another must also be seen in the context of "who can sing the folk?" which will automatically draw us to the unequal relations of power based on caste and class that also envelop folk music. These contestations in their totality, I call the "politics of folk," that is often neglected within the larger discourse of Assamese cultural environment.

NOTES

- 1 I do not mean to see them independently and do recognise the interconnectedness between each of them.
- 2 I am using the word "folk" in double quotes as I do not want to essentialise the concept and understand it as it is understood in common terms. Throughout the article, I attempt to debunk the normative idea of "folk" as that which is inherently connected to a particular region/community in a perennial manner.
- 3 I have used the word "presumably," as there are a lot of contentions over whether the language is Rajbanshi at all.
- 4 Here, I borrow the term from Victor Turner, for whom "liminal" meant entities that are neither here nor there, or are "betwixt and between" (Turner 1969: 95).
- 5 This is an all-women ritual where no men were allowed to be present. This ritual was performed to please the *Hudum* deity or the god of rain. The women usually used to assemble in an uncultivated field, especially at night, with plough and seeds. Then they shed their clothes, untied their hair and danced passionately, all the while singing hymns to *Hudum*. Through these performances, the woman tried to depict their erotic desires as standing for the parched earth's desire for rain (Banerjee 1997:155-56).
- 6 A fusion form of Goalpariya lokageet along with a Punjabi folk song was produced in Coke Studio, Season 3 (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gDOFDwgXrew>). Here, the main instrument of Goalpariya Lokageet that is, *Dotora*, has remained intact, while other instruments like drums, electric guitars, synthesisers have been used to present the song in a very different way.
- 7 The song is called *Hostir Kanya*, sung by the Goalpariya singer Pratima Baruah Pandey <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zykaYOfC-qA>. These songs have been taken from different albums of Pratima Pandey and uploaded on Youtube.
- 8 Translation by the author.
- 9 Both the song and the translation have been taken from Barma (2004: p 184)
- 10 It refers to a specific class of English-educated upper-caste men that arose in 19th-century colonial Bengal. They played an important role in developing certain common standards of behaviour along with their associated social and cultural aesthetics.

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